ing, the insecurity of poverty, the privations of class and caste uncertainty (his surname is the result of his father bribing a clerk) and the squalid memories of his time as a student at IIT Delhi. Early in the novel is a scene of unspeakable 'ragging'. His roommates, equally traumatised, respond in different ways—one, Aseem Thakur, becomes a priapic writer and media entrepreneur with more than a passing resemblance to Tarun Tejpal, and the other, Virendra, a Dalit, becomes a billionaire financier who is imprisoned for "insider trading, money-laundering and tax evasion". Virendra had been financing Aseem's magazine and conclaves of global thinkers. Reflecting on his benefactor's downfall, Aseem notes, in his florid, glib way: "The terrible thing about the trampled-upon darkies like Virendra is that their claim upon the richness of the world came too late. Just before we entered the endgame of modernity...".

Mishra hits upon an intriguing device for *Run and Hide*—Dwivedi's account is addressed to Alia, a privileged, well-educated Muslim woman who is writing the story of Virendra's fraud. Dwivedi is in love with her, and indeed the idea of her, the easy grace and confidence that is the birthright of the wealthy and upper class. The device offers Mishra a means to acknowledge the fragmented nature of Indian experience. "The question, 'Who are you writing for?'," Mishra says during our conversation, "obscures the fact that in India, unlike in cohesive societies, you can't count on a store of shared assumptions. Jane Austen didn't have to explain." If *Run and Hide* doesn't quite add up to the sum of its parts, it remains a revelatory picture of India's fractured, divided, profoundly troubling present. Who wouldn't want to run and hide? ■

–Shougat Dasgupta

BOOKS

DOING JUSTICE



K.R. Meera's recently translated novella, *Qabar*, deals deftly with matters of both state and heart

A perfect book cover is rare enough that sometimes it's worth taking into account when judging a book. This is true of the new English translation of K.R. Meera's 2020 novella, *Qabar*, adorned by a brilliant visual pun that encapsulates the dazzling double meanings and perspectives contained within. A green dome, the silhouette of a Muslim tomb, alludes to the title, but is also the calyx of an upside-down, dried-out 'Edward rose', the mysterious scent of which pervades *Qabar*'s pages. The tension between these two motifs, symbols of death and love, and the feeling of a world tumbling between irreconcilable realities, define this deftly told, disturbing yet bracingly magical tale.

K.R. MEERA plays with different kinds of vision in *Qabar*, such as the kaleidoscopic experience of love or fear

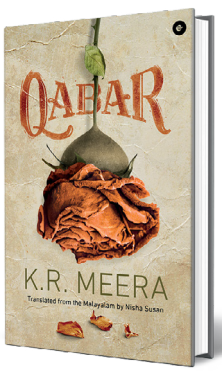
The story begins with additional district judge Bhavana Sachidanand being thrown off balance in her courtroom by a plaintiff who seems to be using djinn-like powers to control her perceptions. Kaakkasseri Khayaluddin Thangal, a disconcertingly well-heeled 'hottie', fills the room with the scent of roses, causes rainbows to dance in the judge's eyes, and conjures up an intimidating spectre from the past. In the courtroom, the preservation of a *qabar* allegedly belonging to Thangal's ancestor, on land that has been sold to a charitable trust, is at the heart of the matter. But despite the weighty connotations of this conflict (the trust's name, Saketam, even alludes to Ayodhya), the story teeters over into matters of the heart.

For a judge, Bhavana is an emotional narrator, whose giddy voice translator Nisha Susan renders into English with zest. The single mother of a boy diagnosed with ADHD, Bhavana reveals that she spent most of her life stamping out her intelligence in deference to her former husband, and that she eventually became a judge because she would be assigned two assistants. We meet her mercurial son Advaith, her self-absorbed ex-husband Pramod, her father who is addicted to TV serials, and her mother who lives independently with a clan of beloved street dogs. Beyond these exceptional but credible characters is Yogeshwaran Ammavan, a fantastical ancestor who returned from Kashi after going there to die, bringing back with him two powerful young goddesses.

About Thangal, the mind-reader, we learn very little until a shocking revelation—dealt with in one line—late in the book. Overwhelmed by her attraction to him, Bhavana pushes his religious identity off to the furthest corner of her narrative while focusing on the challenges she has faced as a woman in a conservative society. Meera plays with different kinds of vision throughout *Qabar*, masterfully capturing the consignment of uncomfortable truths to the periphery, the kaleidoscopic experience of love or fear, and how prejudice often disguises itself as blind justice. Under the book's dust jacket is a gold rose embossed on a dull red cover—just one more of its unending layers. ■

–Sonal Shah





QABAR
By K.R. Meera (Translated by Nisha Susan)
EKA
₹399; 120 pages